

Late Winter / Early Spring

Speech Therapy Story Collection

10 Stories — Dual Versions with Questions, Vocabulary & Image Prompts

All Image Prompts

Use these prompts with Gemini (ImageFX/Imagen) or another AI image generator. All prompts are written for a Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 1: The Melting Snowman

A young girl standing in a backyard on a late winter day. The ground is muddy with patches of melting snow. A carrot and a blue scarf are lying in a small puddle where a snowman used to be. The girl is looking down at the puddle with a sad but thoughtful expression. Bare trees in the background, soft pale sunlight breaking through gray clouds. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 2: The Muddy Dog

A medium-sized brown dog standing outside on a muddy lawn with patches of melting snow. The dog's paws are covered in mud. A woman stands at the back door looking at the dog with a surprised expression. Late winter day, pale sunshine, bare trees. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 3: The Early Robin

A bright red-breasted robin standing on wet muddy ground with patches of snow nearby, pulling a worm from the soil. A young girl watches from a window in the background, her face lit up with excitement. Soft late-winter light, bare tree branches visible. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 4: The Last Snowball

A young boy standing in a backyard on a late winter morning, holding a wet melting snowball. Patches of snow are visible on the ground but most of the yard is muddy and brown. Bare trees in the background, soft pale sunlight. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 5: The Muddy Boots

A young girl on a muddy path on a late winter afternoon, one boot stuck in the mud and one sock-covered foot in the air. She has a laughing expression. Patches of melting snow on the sides of the path, bare trees, gray-blue sky with hints of pale light. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 6: The Frozen Puddle

A young girl stepping on a thin sheet of ice over a large puddle on a sidewalk, the ice cracking under her foot. Her expression is surprised. Late winter morning, patches of snow nearby, bare trees, gray sky with soft light. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 7: The Warm Afternoon

A boy sitting on front porch steps on a warm late-winter afternoon, face tilted up toward pale sunshine, no coat on. Snow is dripping off the roof above him and a bird sits in a bare tree nearby. The yard still has patches of snow but looks muddy. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 8: The Seed Packet

A girl placing small plastic cups filled with soil on a sunny windowsill, a seed packet in her hand. Outside the window, bare trees and patches of snow are visible. Warm indoor light, cozy kitchen setting. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 9: The Ice on the Pond

A boy standing at the edge of a pond in late winter, looking at thin cracking ice on the water. A warning sign is visible near the edge. The surrounding area has patches of melting snow, bare trees, and pale winter sunlight. Slightly wistful mood. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Story 10: The First Warm Rain

A girl standing on a covered porch watching warm rain fall on a yard with rapidly melting snow. Large puddles are forming on the sidewalk. The sky is gray but there is a soft warm light to the scene. Bare trees in the background with the first hints of buds. Pixar-style 3D animation aesthetic.

Stories 1–3: Full Materials

Story 1: The Melting Snowman



Vocabulary Nouns

snowman, carrot, scarf, puddle, mud, fence, flower



Version 1 — Simple

Mia built a snowman in her yard last week. The snowman had a carrot nose and a blue scarf. Now the sun feels warmer and the snow is melting. Mia saw a puddle where the snowman used to be. She felt sad, but then she smiled. She decided to look for the first flower of spring instead.

Literal Questions

Q1: What was in the puddle where the snowman used to be?

 **Hint:** Think about what Mia had put on her snowman.

- A) A hat and mittens
- B) A carrot and a blue scarf ✓**
- C) A flower and some mud
- D) A bucket and a stick

Q2: How did Mia feel when she first saw the puddle?

 **Hint:** The story tells you her feeling directly.

- A) Excited
- B) Angry
- C) Sad ✓**
- D) Surprised

Q3: What did Mia decide to look for at the end of the story?

 **Hint:** It is something that grows and is a sign of spring.

- A) A new scarf
- B) Another snowball
- C) A bird
- D) The first flower of spring ✓**

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why do you think Mia smiled at the end of the story?

 **Hint:** What did she decide to do instead of being sad?

- A) She found her scarf in the puddle
- B) She forgot why she was sad**

- C) Thinking about spring made her feel hopeful ✓**
D) She was ready to build a new snowman

Q2: What does it mean that the snowman melted?

 **Hint:** Think about what makes snow melt. What season might be coming?

- A) Mia did not water her snowman
B) The weather is getting warmer and spring might be coming ✓
C) It rained too hard the night before
D) The snowman was built in the wrong spot

Q3: Why do you think Mia wanted to find a flower instead of building a new snowman?

 **Hint:** She was already thinking about something new — what does that tell you?

- A) She was tired of snowmen
B) She was ready to look forward to spring instead of holding onto winter ✓
C) Flowers are easier to make than snowmen
D) She did not have enough snow left

Version 2 — More Complex

Last week, Mia built the best snowman on her street. She gave him a crooked carrot nose and wrapped her favorite blue scarf around his neck. But as February turned warmer, the snow started to melt a little more each day. One morning, Mia walked outside and found nothing but a puddle, a carrot, and a soggy scarf sitting in the mud. Her stomach sank — it felt like losing a friend. But then she noticed something tiny and green pushing up through the cold dirt near the fence. A flower was starting to grow. Mia picked up her scarf, smiled, and decided that something new beginning wasn't so bad after all.

Literal Questions

Q1: What did Mia find where the snowman used to be?

 **Hint:** Three things were left behind — what were they?

- A) A hat, a scarf, and a stick
B) A puddle, a carrot, and a soggy scarf ✓
C) A carrot, a puddle, and a flower
D) Just a big muddy puddle

Q2: What did Mia notice near the fence?

 **Hint:** It was something small and green pushing through the dirt.

- A) A bird looking for worms
B) A patch of ice that hadn't melted
C) A flower starting to grow ✓

D) Her carrot from the snowman

Q3: What did Mia do with her scarf at the end of the story?

 **Hint:** She had left it on the snowman — what did she do when she found it?

- A) She left it in the mud
- B) She threw it away
- C) She picked it up ✓**
- D) She hung it on the fence

Inferential Questions

Q1: The story says Mia's stomach sank. What does that tell you about how she felt?

 **Hint:** Think about what it feels like when your stomach sinks — is it a happy feeling or a sad one?

- A) She was hungry and wanted breakfast
- B) She felt a sudden sadness when she saw the snowman was gone ✓**
- C) She was confused about what happened to the snowman
- D) She was excited to see the puddle

Q2: Why did Mia smile when she saw the tiny green flower?

 **Hint:** Think about what a flower growing in late winter usually means.

- A) She recognized it as her favorite kind of flower
- B) She thought the flower looked funny coming out of the cold dirt
- C) Seeing something new growing made her feel hopeful about spring ✓**
- D) She wanted to pick it and bring it inside

Q3: What does the story suggest about how Mia felt about winter ending?

 **Hint:** She was sad at first — but how did her feelings change by the end?

- A) She was happy winter was over from the beginning
- B) She never cared about the snowman in the first place
- C) She started sad but found a reason to feel okay about things changing ✓**
- D) She decided she would never build another snowman

Story 2: The Muddy Dog



Vocabulary Nouns

dog, yard, mud, paws, bath, house, garage, tub



Version 1 — Simple

Max the dog ran outside. The snow was melting and the yard was muddy. Max got mud all over his paws. His owner did not want mud in the house. She gave Max a bath. Max did not like the bath, but he was clean.

Literal Questions

Q1: Where did Max get muddy?

 **Hint:** Where did Max run at the start of the story?

- A) At the park
- B) In the yard ✓**
- C) In the house
- D) At the lake

Q2: What did Max's owner do to clean him up?

 **Hint:** What do you do when something is dirty and needs to get clean?

- A) She put him outside again
- B) She gave him food
- C) She gave him a bath ✓**
- D) She dried his paws with a towel

Q3: How did Max feel about the bath?

 **Hint:** The story tells you directly.

- A) He loved it
- B) He fell asleep
- C) He did not like it ✓**
- D) He did not care

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why didn't Max's owner let him inside right away?

 **Hint:** Think about what was on Max's paws.

- A) She was busy cooking dinner
- B) Max was too loud

C) She did not want mud tracked into the house ✓

D) Max was not allowed inside until later

Q2: Why was the yard so muddy?

 **Hint:** The story says something was happening to the snow.

A) It had been raining for days

B) Someone left the hose on

C) The snow was melting ✓

D) Max had been digging holes

Q3: How do you think Max felt when he first ran outside?

 **Hint:** He had probably been inside all winter — think about how that might feel.

A) Scared because it was cold

B) Happy to finally be free outside ✓

C) Confused about where he was

D) Tired and ready to come back in

Version 2 — More Complex

Max had been stuck inside all winter, so the moment his owner opened the back door, he shot outside like a rocket. The snow was melting fast, and the yard had turned into a muddy mess. Max ran back and forth across the wet ground, completely happy. When he finally came to the door, all four paws were caked in dark mud. His owner shook her head and pointed back at the yard. She grabbed an old plastic tub from the garage, filled it with water, and gave Max a bath right there outside. Max whined the whole time, but when it was over he was clean — and already eyeing the muddy yard again.

Literal Questions

Q1: Why was the yard so muddy?

 **Hint:** What was happening to the snow?

A) It had been raining for days

B) Max had been digging holes all morning

C) The snow was melting ✓

D) Someone left the hose running overnight

Q2: Where did Max's owner get the tub?

 **Hint:** She had to go get it from somewhere nearby.

A) The basement

B) The bathroom

C) The garage ✓

D) The hallway closet

Q3: How did Max act during his bath?

 **Hint:** The story uses a specific word to describe the sound he made.

- A) He barked at the water
- B) He whined the whole time ✓**
- C) He stood perfectly still
- D) He tried to run away

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why did Max's owner shake her head and point back at the yard?

 **Hint:** She didn't say anything — but think about what she saw when she looked at him.

- A) She wanted Max to keep playing outside
- B) She was worried he would slip on the floor
- C) She did not want muddy paw prints all through the house ✓**
- D) Max was not allowed inside until dinnertime

Q2: Why do you think Max ran outside like a rocket?

 **Hint:** Think about how long he had been cooped up inside.

- A) He heard another dog barking outside
- B) He was chasing a squirrel
- C) After being stuck inside all winter he was ready to run ✓**
- D) He was trying to get away from his owner

Q3: At the end, Max was already eyeing the muddy yard again. What does that tell you about Max?

 **Hint:** Think about what Max seemed to love most in this story.

- A) Max was looking for a dry spot to lie down
- B) Max wanted to go back in the mud even though he just got clean ✓**
- C) Max was watching for other animals in the yard
- D) Max forgot he had just taken a bath

Story 3: The Early Robin

Vocabulary Nouns

robin, yard, worms, ground, girl, window, spring, notebook

Version 1 — Simple

A robin flew into the yard. It was one of the first warm days. The bird looked for worms in the wet ground. A girl saw the robin from her window. She was excited. She knew spring was getting close.

Literal Questions

Q1: What was the robin looking for?

 **Hint:** Think about what birds like to eat that live in the ground.

- A) Seeds
- B) Berries
- C) Worms ✓**
- D) Bugs on the tree

Q2: Where was the girl when she saw the robin?

 **Hint:** She did not go outside — she looked from inside.

- A) On the porch
- B) In the yard
- C) At her window ✓**
- D) At school

Q3: How did the girl feel when she saw the robin?

 **Hint:** The story tells you her feeling directly.

- A) Confused
- B) Scared
- C) Bored
- D) Excited ✓**

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why was the girl excited to see the robin?

 **Hint:** The last sentence of the story gives you a big clue.

- A) She wanted to catch the bird
- B) She had never seen a bird before

- C) **Seeing the robin meant spring was coming ✓**
- D) The robin was her pet

Q2: Why was the ground wet?

 **Hint:** Think about what happens to snow when the weather gets warmer.

- A) It had been raining all week
- B) Someone watered the yard
- C) **The snow was melting ✓**
- D) There was a puddle from the sprinklers

Q3: What does it tell you that robins come back when the ground is wet and warm?

 **Hint:** Think about what the robin was looking for and where that lives in the ground.

- A) Robins like to play in mud
- B) **Worms come closer to the surface when the ground warms up, making them easier to find ✓**
- C) Robins are afraid of snow
- D) The robin was lost and looking for its nest

Version 2 — More Complex

Every February, Dani watched the backyard like she was waiting for something. And she was. The first robin of the season was her personal sign that winter was finally loosening its grip. On a Tuesday morning, with frost still clinging to the grass and a few stubborn patches of snow in the corners of the yard, she spotted it — a plump little bird with a rust-red chest, hopping across the muddy ground and jabbing its beak into the soil. Dani pressed her face against the cold glass. She knew robins came back when the ground started to thaw, when worms began moving closer to the surface. Seeing that bird meant the cold wasn't going to last forever. She grabbed her notebook and wrote down the date, just like she did every year.

Literal Questions

Q1: What was the robin doing in the yard?

 **Hint:** Think about what it was using its beak for.

- A) Building a nest in the mud
- B) Looking for seeds near the fence
- C) **Jabbing its beak into the ground to find worms ✓**
- D) Drinking water from a puddle

Q2: What did Dani do after she saw the robin?

 **Hint:** She did something she does every single year.

- A) She ran outside to get a closer look
- B) She called her mom to come see

C) She wrote the date in her notebook ✓

D) She took a picture with her phone

Q3: What did the yard look like that morning?

 **Hint:** The story describes two things still left from winter.

A) Covered in deep snow with icy trees

B) Frost on the grass and patches of snow in the corners ✓

C) Muddy with puddles everywhere and no snow left

D) Green and sunny with flowers starting to bloom

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why does Dani write down the date every year when she sees the first robin?

 **Hint:** Think about what the robin means to her — why would that date feel important?

A) She was doing a school science project about birds

B) The date is special because the robin signals that winter is ending ✓

C) She wanted to remember what the bird looked like

D) Her teacher asked her to track the weather each day

Q2: The story says winter was loosening its grip. What does that mean?

 **Hint:** Think about what a grip is — and what winter does to the weather.

A) Winter was getting stronger and colder

B) Winter storms were becoming more dangerous

C) Winter was slowly coming to an end ✓

D) The wind was starting to pick up again

Q3: Why do robins come back when the ground starts to thaw?

 **Hint:** The story actually explains this — think about what the robin was looking for and where that lives.

A) They follow the wind patterns north each year

B) They prefer muddy ground to build their nests

C) Worms move closer to the surface when the ground warms up, making them easier to find ✓

D) They come back to the same yard where they were born

Stories 4–10: Full Materials

The following stories continue the late winter / early spring theme with the same format: dual versions, literal and inferential questions with hints and multiple choice, vocabulary, and image prompts.

Story 4: The Last Snowball

Vocabulary Nouns

snowball, snow, tree, morning, ground, hands, oak, roof

Version 1 — Simple

Jake went outside on a cold morning. There was still some snow on the ground. He picked up the wet snow and made a snowball. The snow was soft and fell apart in his hands. Jake knew the snow would be gone soon. He threw the last snowball at a tree and smiled.

Literal Questions

Q1: What did Jake make with the snow?

 **Hint:** It is something you can throw.

- A) A snowman
- B) A snowball ✓**
- C) A snow fort
- D) A pile of snow

Q2: What did Jake throw the snowball at?

 **Hint:** It was something in the yard.

- A) A fence
- B) A bush
- C) A tree ✓**
- D) A wall

Q3: What was wrong with the snow?

 **Hint:** The story says it did something in his hands.

- A) It was too dry and hard
- B) It was yellow
- C) It was soft and fell apart ✓**
- D) It was frozen solid

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why did Jake think the snow would be gone soon?

 **Hint:** Think about what the snow felt like and what time of year it might be.

- A) The forecast said it would snow again

- B) The snow was wet and melting, a sign warmer weather was coming ✓**
- C) His mom told him the snow was leaving
- D) He had seen all the snow melt before

Q2: Why do you think Jake smiled after throwing the snowball?

 **Hint:** Think about what this snowball might mean — it could be the last one of the year.

- A) He was happy he did not miss the tree
- B) He was enjoying one last winter moment before it ended ✓**
- C) He was excited to go back inside
- D) He was proud of how far he threw it

Q3: How do you think Jake felt about winter ending?

 **Hint:** He went outside just to make one snowball — what does that tell you?

- A) He was glad winter was over
- B) He did not care either way
- C) He was a little sad to see winter go ✓**
- D) He was angry that the snow was melting

Version 2 — More Complex

Jake woke up and checked the yard before he even had breakfast. There was still snow on the ground, but just barely — thin patches of it clinging to the shady corners of the yard. He pulled on his boots and went outside. The snow was wet and heavy, not the dry fluffy kind from January. He packed a handful together and the snowball started falling apart before he even drew his arm back. Jake looked at it for a second. He knew this was probably the last snow of the year. He threw it anyway, right at the old oak tree, and watched the wet clump splatter against the bark. Then he stood there for a minute, listening to the dripping sound of snow melting off the roof.

Literal Questions

Q1: When did Jake check the yard?

 **Hint:** The story says he did it before something else.

- A) After school
- B) Before breakfast ✓**
- C) After dinner
- D) Before bed

Q2: What kind of snow was it?

 **Hint:** The story compares it to snow from a different month.

- A) Dry and fluffy like January snow
- B) Icy and hard to pick up**

- C) Wet and heavy, not like January snow ✓**
- D) Light and powdery

Q3: What did Jake throw the snowball at?

 **Hint:** It was a specific tree in the yard.

- A) A fence post
- B) A pine tree
- C) The old oak tree ✓**
- D) The side of the house

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why were the snow patches only in the shady corners of the yard?

 **Hint:** Think about what sunshine does to snow.

- A) The wind pushed all the snow to the corners
- B) It had only snowed in those spots
- C) The sun melted the snow everywhere except the shady areas ✓**
- D) Someone shoveled the snow into the corners

Q2: Why did Jake stand quietly at the end of the story?

 **Hint:** Think about what he was listening to and what it meant.

- A) He was trying to hear birds singing
- B) He was waiting for his mom to call him inside
- C) He was taking in a last quiet winter moment before it was gone ✓**
- D) He was listening for other kids playing outside

Q3: What does the dripping sound of snow melting off the roof tell you?

 **Hint:** What has to happen for snow to drip?

- A) It started raining while Jake was outside
- B) The snow was melting because the temperature was rising ✓**
- C) Someone turned on the heat too high in the house
- D) The roof was leaking from all the heavy snow

Story 5: The Muddy Boots

Vocabulary Nouns

path, boots, mud, sock, school, home, field, shortcut

Version 1 — Simple

Lily walked home from school. The path was muddy from the melting snow. Her boots got stuck in the mud. She pulled hard and her boot came off. Her sock got wet and muddy. Lily laughed and kept walking home.

Literal Questions

Q1: Where did Lily's boot get stuck?

 **Hint:** Think about what was covering the path.

- A) In a puddle
- B) In the mud ✓**
- C) In the snow
- D) In the grass

Q2: What happened when she pulled her boot out?

 **Hint:** Something came off along with the mud.

- A) Her boot ripped
- B) She fell down
- C) Her boot came off ✓**
- D) Her laces broke

Q3: How did Lily react when her sock got muddy?

 **Hint:** She did not cry or get upset — the story tells you exactly what she did.

- A) She sat down and waited
- B) She cried
- C) She laughed ✓**
- D) She called her mom

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why was the path so muddy?

 **Hint:** Think about what happens to snow when it gets warmer outside.

- A) It had been raining all day

- B) The snow was melting and making the ground wet ✓**
- C) Someone had watered the path
- D) The path was always muddy in winter

Q2: Why do you think Lily's boot came off when she pulled?

 **Hint:** Think about how mud works — what does it do to things that sink into it?

- A) Her boot was too old and worn out
- B) The mud held the boot tight while her foot kept moving ✓**
- C) Her boot was too big for her foot
- D) She pulled in the wrong direction

Q3: What does it tell you about Lily that she laughed and kept walking?

 **Hint:** Most people would be really upset — what does laughing tell you about her personality?

- A) She did not notice her sock was wet
- B) She thought getting muddy was funny and did not let it ruin her day ✓**
- C) She was happy to have an excuse to be late
- D) She was laughing at someone else

Version 2 — More Complex

Lily took the shortcut home even though she knew the path through the field got muddy this time of year. The snow had been melting for days, and the ground was soft and soggy in a way that pulled at her boots with every step. She was halfway across when her left boot sank deep into a thick patch of mud and stopped moving. Lily kept walking — and her foot slid right out, leaving her standing with one boot on and one sock planted in cold wet mud. She looked down at her sock, then back at her boot still standing upright in the mud like it had decided to stay. Lily burst out laughing. She reached back, yanked the boot free with a loud sucking sound, and squished the rest of the way home.

Literal Questions

Q1: Why did Lily's boot get stuck?

 **Hint:** Think about what the ground was like after days of melting snow.

- A) Her boot laces were tied too tight
- B) She stepped in a deep patch of mud ✓**
- C) She slipped on a patch of ice
- D) Her boot caught on a root

Q2: What did Lily's boot look like after it got stuck?

 **Hint:** The story describes what the boot looked like when she looked back at it.

- A) It was lying on its side in the mud

- B) It was standing upright in the mud by itself ✓**
- C) It had sunk all the way under the mud
- D) It was floating in a puddle

Q3: How did Lily get her boot out?

 **Hint:** The story describes the sound it made when she pulled it free.

- A) She wiggled it back and forth slowly
- B) She used a stick to pry it out
- C) She yanked it free with a loud sucking sound ✓**
- D) She waited for the mud to dry a little first

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why did Lily take the shortcut even though she knew it would be muddy?

 **Hint:** Think about why people take shortcuts in the first place.

- A) She forgot it would be muddy this time of year
- B) She wanted to get home faster and took the chance ✓**
- C) Her mom told her to take that path
- D) The regular path was blocked by snow

Q2: What does it mean that the mud made a sucking sound when she pulled the boot free?

 **Hint:** Think about what thick wet mud does when something is pulled out of it.

- A) There were bugs living in the mud making noise
- B) The mud was so thick and wet it created suction around the boot ✓**
- C) Lily was making the sound herself as she pulled
- D) The ground was hollow underneath the mud

Q3: Why do you think Lily burst out laughing instead of getting upset?

 **Hint:** Picture the scene — one boot on, one sock in the mud, the boot standing there alone.

What might that look like?

- A) She was relieved her boot was not ruined
- B) The whole situation was so silly looking she could not help but laugh ✓**
- C) She was laughing because she was cold and nervous
- D) She thought someone was watching and wanted to seem cool

Story 6: The Frozen Puddle

Vocabulary Nouns

puddle, ice, shoe, sidewalk, school, foot, sneaker, crack

Version 1 — Simple

Anna found a big puddle on her way to school. The puddle had a thin layer of ice on top. She stepped on the ice to see what would happen. The ice cracked and her shoe got wet. Anna shook her foot and kept walking. She would not step on ice again.

Literal Questions

Q1: What did Anna find on her way to school?

 **Hint:** It was on the ground and had ice on top.

- A) A snowball
- B) A frozen puddle ✓**
- C) A patch of snow
- D) A crack in the sidewalk

Q2: What happened when Anna stepped on the ice?

 **Hint:** Ice that is very thin does not hold much weight.

- A) She slipped and fell
- B) The ice held and she slid across
- C) The ice cracked and her shoe got wet ✓**
- D) The puddle splashed on her coat

Q3: What did Anna do after her shoe got wet?

 **Hint:** She did two things — she reacted and then she moved on.

- A) She sat down on the curb
- B) She shook her foot and kept walking ✓**
- C) She went back home to change
- D) She called her mom for help

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why was there ice on top of the puddle?

 **Hint:** Think about what temperature makes water turn to ice.

- A) Someone poured water on the puddle overnight

- B) It was still cold enough at night to freeze the water ✓**
- C) The puddle was in the shade all day
- D) The ice had been there since December

Q2: Why do you think Anna stepped on the ice?

 **Hint:** Think about what kids often wonder when they see something like thin ice.

- A) She did not see the puddle in time
- B) She was curious and wanted to see what would happen ✓**
- C) She was trying to slide across it
- D) She had no other way around it

Q3: What does it mean that Anna would not step on ice again?

 **Hint:** She learned something from what happened — what was the lesson?

- A) She decided she did not like winter anymore
- B) She learned from her mistake and would be more careful next time ✓**
- C) She was going to take a different route to school
- D) She was upset and wanted to go home

Version 2 — More Complex

Anna almost walked right past it, but something made her stop. The puddle was wide and flat, and the top of it had frozen overnight into a thin cloudy sheet of ice. She could see the water still liquid underneath. She knew she probably should not, but she pressed the toe of her sneaker against the edge just to test it. The ice held for about one second before it gave way with a sharp crack, and cold water rushed over her shoe. Anna gasped and jumped back, shaking her foot. Her sneaker was soaked through. She stood there for a moment, looking at the broken ice floating in the puddle, and then kept walking toward school. It had seemed worth testing at the time.

Literal Questions

Q1: What did the ice look like on top of the puddle?

 **Hint:** The story uses two words to describe it.

- A) Clear and shiny like glass
- B) Thick and white like a snowball
- C) Thin and cloudy ✓**
- D) Dark and rough like gravel

Q2: How did Anna first test the ice?

 **Hint:** She did not step on it fully at first — she used just one part of her foot.

- A) She jumped on it with both feet
- B) She tapped it with a stick**

- C) **She pressed the toe of her sneaker against the edge ✓**
- D) She poked it with her finger

Q3: What happened right after the ice cracked?

 **Hint:** Two things happened very quickly — what did the water do and what did Anna do?

- A) Anna slipped and the puddle splashed her coat
- B) **Cold water rushed over her shoe and Anna gasped and jumped back ✓**
- C) Anna fell in and got her whole leg wet
- D) The ice held for a moment and then slowly sank

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why did the puddle have ice on top but liquid water underneath?

 **Hint:** Think about how temperatures change between night and day in late winter.

- A) **The puddle was too deep to freeze all the way through in one night ✓**
- B) Someone poured warm water into the puddle that morning
- C) The puddle was in a sunny spot that kept the bottom warm
- D) Ice always floats so the water underneath stays liquid forever

Q2: Anna says it seemed worth testing at the time. What does that tell you?

 **Hint:** Think about whether she regrets it — and whether she is being serious or a little funny about it.

- A) She thinks it was a smart decision and would do it again
- B) **She is being a little wry — she knew it was risky but did it anyway and accepts what happened ✓**
- C) She is very upset and wishes she had never touched the puddle
- D) She thinks the ice should have been stronger and is blaming the weather

Q3: Why do you think Anna kept walking to school instead of going home?

 **Hint:** Think about how serious a wet shoe actually is — and what her goal was that morning.

- A) She did not realize her shoe was wet
- B) She was too embarrassed to turn around
- C) **A wet shoe was not worth being late or missing school over ✓**
- D) Her house was too far away to go back

Story 7: The Warm Afternoon

Vocabulary Nouns

afternoon, coat, sun, steps, roof, bird, tree, chickadee

Version 1 — Simple

It was a warm afternoon in late February. Tom went outside without his coat. The sun felt good on his face. He sat on the steps and watched the snow drip off the roof. A bird sang in the tree above him. Tom did not want to go back inside.

Literal Questions

Q1: What did Tom leave behind when he went outside?

 **Hint:** It is something you wear when it is cold out.

- A) His hat
- B) His coat ✓**
- C) His boots
- D) His gloves

Q2: Where did Tom sit outside?

 **Hint:** It was right outside his house.

- A) On the grass
- B) On a bench
- C) On the steps ✓**
- D) On a chair

Q3: What did Tom watch dripping off the roof?

 **Hint:** Think about what was on the roof that was melting.

- A) Rain
- B) Ice
- C) Snow ✓**
- D) Water from the gutter

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why did Tom go outside without his coat?

 **Hint:** The story tells you what kind of afternoon it was.

- A) He forgot it inside
- B) He was only going out for a second**

- C) It was warm enough that he did not need one ✓**
D) His coat was wet from the day before

Q2: What does the snow dripping off the roof tell you about the weather?

 **Hint:** What has to happen for snow to drip?

- A) It was windy and blowing the snow off
B) It was warm enough to melt the snow ✓
C) Someone was on the roof clearing it off
D) It had started to rain

Q3: Why did Tom not want to go back inside?

 **Hint:** Think about how long winter had probably felt and how the warm sun felt to him.

- A) He was waiting for a friend to arrive
B) He had nothing to do inside
C) The warmth felt so good after a long cold winter ✓
D) His favorite show was not on yet

Version 2 — More Complex

It was one of those late February days that felt like a promise. Tom stepped outside after lunch without even grabbing his coat — something he had not been able to do in months. The sun was low but warm on his face, and the air smelled different, almost like wet dirt and something green trying to wake up. He sat down on the front steps and just stayed there. Water dripped steadily from the edge of the roof where the snow was letting go. A chickadee called from somewhere in the bare oak tree above him. Tom was not doing anything in particular — just sitting, listening, feeling the warmth. It was not quite spring, but it was not really winter anymore either.

Literal Questions

Q1: What time of day did Tom go outside?

 **Hint:** The story says he went out after something.

- A) Before breakfast
B) After lunch ✓
C) After school
D) Before dinner

Q2: What was dripping from the edge of the roof?

 **Hint:** Think about what was up there that was melting.

- A) Rain from the gutters
B) Ice from a frozen pipe

- C) Water from melting snow ✓**
- D) Water from a sprinkler on the roof

Q3: What bird did Tom hear in the tree?

 **Hint:** The story names the bird specifically.

- A) A robin
- B) A sparrow
- C) A chickadee ✓**
- D) A blue jay

Inferential Questions

Q1: The story says the day felt like a promise. What does that mean?

 **Hint:** Think about what season comes after winter — what might a warm February day be promising?

- A) Tom had promised himself he would go outside that day
- B) The warm day felt like a sign that spring was on its way ✓**
- C) Someone had promised Tom it would be a nice day
- D) The weather forecast had promised sunshine all week

Q2: Why did the air smell like wet dirt and something green trying to wake up?

 **Hint:** Think about what happens underground when the ground starts to thaw and warm up.

- A) Someone nearby was gardening
- B) The rain had washed away the snow and left fresh dirt
- C) The ground was warming up and plants were starting to grow again ✓**
- D) Tom was sitting next to a garden bed

Q3: What does the last line mean — it was not quite spring but not really winter anymore either?

 **Hint:** Think about where February falls — right between the two seasons.

- A) Tom did not know what month it was
- B) The weather was confused and kept changing
- C) The season was in a transition — caught between winter ending and spring beginning ✓**
- D) It was technically still winter but Tom did not believe it

Story 8: The Seed Packet

Vocabulary Nouns

seeds, garage, ground, cups, soil, window, seedlings, sunflowers

Version 1 — Simple

Maria found an old seed packet in the garage. She wanted to plant the seeds. The ground outside was still too cold. Maria put the seeds in small cups with soil. She put them by the sunny window. She waited for the seeds to grow.

Literal Questions

Q1: Where did Maria find the seed packet?

 **Hint:** It is a place where people store things, usually attached to the house.

- A) In the kitchen cabinet
- B) In her room
- C) In the garage ✓**
- D) In the backyard

Q2: Why did Maria not plant the seeds outside?

 **Hint:** Think about what seeds need to grow and what the ground felt like.

- A) She did not have a shovel
- B) The ground was still too cold ✓**
- C) It was raining outside
- D) She was not allowed in the yard

Q3: Where did Maria put the cups of seeds?

 **Hint:** She put them somewhere inside where they could get light.

- A) In the basement
- B) On the kitchen table
- C) By the sunny window ✓**
- D) On the back porch

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why did Maria use cups with soil instead of planting outside?

 **Hint:** She still wanted the seeds to grow — she just had to find another way.

- A) She did not know how to plant in the ground

- B) She wanted to start growing indoors since it was still too cold outside ✓**
- C) Her mom told her to use cups
- D) The seed packet said to use cups

Q2: Why did Maria put the cups by the window?

 **Hint:** Think about what plants need to grow besides water and soil.

- A) So she would not forget to water them
- B) Because the window was the warmest spot in the house
- C) So the seeds could get sunlight ✓**
- D) So she could see them from outside

Q3: What does it tell you about Maria that she started seeds inside instead of waiting?

 **Hint:** She did not give up just because it was too cold — what does that say about her?

- A) She was impatient and not very smart about gardening
- B) She was creative and determined to find a way to start spring early ✓**
- C) She did not understand how plants grow
- D) She was bored and just wanted something to do

Version 2 — More Complex

Maria had been watching the snow melt for weeks, and she was done waiting for spring. She dug through the shelves in the garage until she found what she was looking for — a crinkled seed packet with a picture of sunflowers on the front, left over from last summer. The ground outside was still frozen a few inches down, too cold to plant anything real yet. But Maria had a plan. She filled six small plastic cups with potting soil, pressed two seeds into each one, and lined them up on the sunniest windowsill in the kitchen. Her mom looked at the row of cups and raised an eyebrow. Maria just shrugged. By the time the ground was ready outside, her seedlings would already have a head start.

Literal Questions

Q1: What kind of seeds did Maria find?

 **Hint:** The seed packet had a picture of them on the front.

- A) Tomato seeds
- B) Sunflower seeds ✓**
- C) Vegetable seeds
- D) Rose seeds

Q2: How many cups did Maria fill with soil?

 **Hint:** The story gives you the exact number.

- A) Four
- B) Eight**

- C) Six ✓
- D) Ten

Q3: How many seeds did Maria put in each cup?

 **Hint:** The story tells you exactly.

- A) One
- B) Two ✓**
- C) Three
- D) As many as she could fit

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why was the ground still too cold to plant in?

 **Hint:** Think about what late February weather does to the ground even when it is starting to warm up on the surface.

- A) It had snowed the night before and covered everything
- B) The ground freezes deep and takes longer to warm up than the air ✓**
- C) Maria's yard was always shady and never warmed up in winter
- D) The seeds needed warm rain to grow and it had not rained yet

Q2: Why did Maria's mom raise an eyebrow when she saw the cups?

 **Hint:** Think about what it might look like to see six cups of dirt lined up on a kitchen windowsill.

- A) She was angry that Maria had gone into the garage
- B) She thought the cups were in the way and wanted them moved
- C) She was surprised and maybe a little skeptical of Maria's indoor garden plan ✓**
- D) She did not know where Maria had gotten the soil

Q3: What does Maria mean when she says the seedlings would have a head start?

 **Hint:** Think about a race — what does it mean to start ahead of everyone else?

- A) The seeds would grow faster than normal because of the window
- B) By starting inside early the plants would already be growing by the time she could plant outside ✓**
- C) Maria wanted to finish her project before her classmates did theirs
- D) The seeds would be ready to eat sooner than store-bought ones

Story 9: The Ice on the Pond

Vocabulary Nouns

pond, ice, sign, home, skates, fence, boot, cracks

Version 1 — Simple

Sam walked to the pond near his house. All winter, he had skated on the ice. Now the ice was thin and cracked. A sign said Do Not Walk on Ice. Sam looked at the pond for a long time. He turned around and walked home.

Literal Questions

Q1: What had Sam done on the pond all winter?

 **Hint:** It is something you do on ice with special shoes.

- A) Walked across it
- B) Skated on it ✓**
- C) Played hockey on it
- D) Sledded on the edge of it

Q2: What did the sign at the pond say?

 **Hint:** It was a warning to keep people safe.

- A) No Swimming
- B) Stay Back
- C) Do Not Walk on Ice ✓**
- D) Pond Closed

Q3: What did Sam do after reading the sign?

 **Hint:** He did not go on the ice — he made a safe choice.

- A) He called his friends to come look
- B) He tested the ice with his foot
- C) He turned around and walked home ✓**
- D) He waited to see if anyone else would go on

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why was the ice thin and cracked?

 **Hint:** Think about what happens to ice when the weather starts to get warmer.

- A) Too many people had skated on it that winter
- B) The ice was old and had never been very thick

- C) **The warming temperatures were melting the ice ✓**
D) Someone had broken the ice with a stick

Q2: Why do you think Sam looked at the pond for a long time before leaving?

💡 **Hint:** Think about what the pond meant to him all winter long.

- A) He was trying to decide if the ice was safe enough
B) **He was sad to see his favorite winter activity coming to an end ✓**
C) He was looking for something he had dropped on the ice
D) He was waiting for a friend to arrive

Q3: What does it tell you about Sam that he followed the sign and went home?

💡 **Hint:** It probably was not easy — he loved skating there. What does going home anyway show?

- A) He was afraid of the water
B) **He was responsible and made a safe choice even though it was hard ✓**
C) He did not really want to skate that day anyway
D) He planned to come back later when no one was watching

Version 2 — More Complex

All winter, the pond at the end of Sam's street had been solid enough to skate on. He had been out there almost every weekend since December, sometimes with friends, sometimes just by himself. But when he showed up on a Saturday in late February, things looked different. The ice was no longer smooth and white — it had taken on a gray glassy look, and he could see thin cracks running out from the edges. A handwritten sign zip-tied to the fence read: DO NOT WALK ON ICE. Sam stood at the edge for a while, his skates over his shoulder. He pressed the toe of his boot against the very edge of the ice and felt it give slightly, like it was sighing. He stepped back. He stayed another few minutes just looking at the pond, at the gray sky reflected in the patches of open water near the middle, and then turned and headed home. The season was over.

Literal Questions

Q1: How often had Sam skated at the pond during winter?

💡 **Hint:** The story tells you how frequently he was there.

- A) Every day after school
B) **Almost every weekend since December ✓**
C) A few times in January
D) Whenever his friends invited him

Q2: What did the ice look like when Sam arrived in February?

💡 **Hint:** The story describes its color and what was visible on it.

- A) White and smooth like earlier in the season
- B) Blue and thick with a few scratches from skates
- C) Gray and glassy with thin cracks running from the edges ✓**
- D) Completely melted with only puddles left

Q3: What did Sam feel when he pressed his boot against the ice?

 **Hint:** The story describes it in an unusual way — like the ice was doing something.

- A) The ice was rock solid and did not move at all
- B) The ice cracked loudly under his boot
- C) The ice gave slightly like it was sighing ✓**
- D) His boot slipped and he almost fell in

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why did the ice turn gray instead of staying white?

 **Hint:** Think about what happens to ice as it starts to weaken and melt from warmer temperatures.

- A) The ice had gotten dirty from skaters all winter
- B) Melting and weakening ice often becomes gray and glassy as it loses its structure ✓**
- C) The sky was gray and reflecting onto the ice
- D) The pond water underneath was dark and showing through

Q2: Why do you think Sam stayed at the pond for a few extra minutes even after deciding not to skate?

 **Hint:** Think about what this place meant to him and what the last line of the story says.

- A) He was hoping the ice would look safer if he waited
- B) He wanted to make sure no one else tried to skate
- C) He was not ready to let go of something that had meant a lot to him all winter ✓**
- D) He was waiting to see if his friends would show up

Q3: What does the last line — the season was over — tell you about how Sam felt?

 **Hint:** It is only four words but they carry a lot of weight — how does a short sentence like that feel compared to a long excited one?

- A) Sam was relieved and ready for spring
- B) Sam was stating a simple fact without any emotion
- C) Sam felt a quiet sadness about winter skating coming to an end ✓**
- D) Sam was angry that the ice had melted too soon

Story 10: The First Warm Rain

Vocabulary Nouns

rain, yard, snow, puddles, sidewalk, porch, spring, branches, buds

Version 1 — Simple

It rained on a Tuesday in late February. But this rain felt different. It was warm, not cold. The snow in the yard started to melt fast. Puddles grew big on the sidewalk. Maya stood on the porch and watched the rain fall. She smiled because she knew spring was almost here.

Literal Questions

Q1: What was different about this rain?

 **Hint:** Think about how rain usually feels in winter versus this rain.

- A) It was raining harder than usual
- B) It was warm rain instead of cold ✓**
- C) It was mixed with snow
- D) It lasted longer than usual

Q2: What happened to the snow in the yard?

 **Hint:** Think about what warm rain does to snow.

- A) The snow got deeper
- B) The snow turned to ice
- C) The snow started to melt fast ✓**
- D) The snow blew away in the wind

Q3: Where was Maya when she watched the rain?

 **Hint:** She was outside but still covered and dry.

- A) At the window inside
- B) In the backyard
- C) On the porch ✓**
- D) Under a tree

Inferential Questions

Q1: Why did Maya smile while watching the rain?

 **Hint:** The last sentence of the story gives you the answer.

- A) She liked getting wet in the rain

- B) She knew the warm rain meant spring was almost here ✓**
- C) She was happy she did not have to go to school
- D) She saw a rainbow starting to form

Q2: Why did the puddles grow so big?

 **Hint:** There were two sources of water — rain and something else.

- A) The gutters were clogged and overflowing
- B) The rain was coming down too fast for the drains to handle
- C) Both the rain and the rapidly melting snow were adding water to the ground ✓**
- D) The yard had a lot of low spots that collected water

Q3: What does warm rain in late February tell you about the weather?

 **Hint:** Think about what has to change for rain to feel warm instead of cold.

- A) A big storm was coming from the south
- B) The temperature was rising and winter was losing its grip ✓**
- C) February is always warmer than January
- D) The rain came from a warm cloud that formed over the ocean

Version 2 — More Complex

The rain that started on Tuesday was different from the cold stinging kind that had fallen in January. This rain was warm — not warm like summer, but warm enough that Maya did not reach for her coat when she stepped onto the porch to watch it. The snow in the yard was disappearing fast, collapsing in on itself and spreading into wide shallow puddles across the sidewalk and driveway. Maya could hear it — the constant dripping and rushing of water moving everywhere at once, finding every low spot in the yard. The bare branches of the oak tree were glistening, and she noticed something she had not seen in months: the very tips of the branches had tiny swollen buds on them. They had not opened yet, but they were there. Maya pulled her sleeves over her hands and leaned against the porch railing. Winter was not gone, but it was leaving.

Literal Questions

Q1: How was this rain different from January rain?

 **Hint:** The story compares the two directly.

- A) It was raining much harder than in January
- B) It was warm rain unlike the cold stinging kind in January ✓**
- C) The rain in January had been mixed with snow
- D) This rain came with thunder unlike January rain

Q2: What did Maya notice on the tips of the oak tree's branches?

 **Hint:** She had not seen these in months — they were very small and had not opened yet.

- A) Small birds sitting in a row
- B) Drops of rain hanging from the twigs
- C) Tiny swollen buds ✓**
- D) The first green leaves of the season

Q3: What was Maya doing when she leaned on the porch railing?

 **Hint:** She was not doing anything active — she was just watching and listening.

- A) She was trying to see if the rain was stopping
- B) She was waiting for someone to arrive
- C) She was quietly taking in the signs of winter ending ✓**
- D) She was checking if the porch steps were icy

Inferential Questions

Q1: The story says the snow was collapsing in on itself. What does that image tell you about how the snow was melting?

 **Hint:** Think about what happens to a snowpile when it loses its structure from below.

- A) The snow was blowing away in chunks from the wind
- B) The snow was melting from the bottom and losing its shape as it fell apart ✓**
- C) The rain was so heavy it was pushing the snow down flat
- D) The snow had gotten old and dry and was crumbling

Q2: Why do you think Maya pulled her sleeves over her hands instead of going inside to get a coat?

 **Hint:** Think about what she was watching — did she want to leave?

- A) All her coats were wet from earlier
- B) She did not realize how cold she was until it was too late
- C) She did not want to go inside and miss the moment she was watching ✓**
- D) She was planning to go inside in just a minute

Q3: What does the last line — winter was not gone but it was leaving — mean?

 **Hint:** Think about what Maya saw and heard — the warm rain, the puddles, the buds. What season does all of that point toward?

- A) The weather forecast said winter would return next week
- B) Maya was not sure if it was winter or spring anymore
- C) The signs of change were clear even if winter had not fully ended yet ✓**
- D) Maya was hoping winter would stay a little longer